

Tips and resources for using Generative AI for Career Development – USD Career Development Center

The world of work is evolving faster than ever, and new technologies are reshaping how we explore, learn, connect, and prepare for our futures. This guide offers practical resources and tips to help you leverage Generative AI ethically, thoughtfully, and effectively as you explore career options, build skills, and prepare and embark on your career endeavors. The AI tools and guides provided are powerful resources designed for skill development and content support. They are here to help you explore, refine, and research; they are not a replacement for your personal effort, work, critical thinking, or the professional advice of our Career Development Center staff.

The University of San Diego Career Development Center does not guarantee the factual accuracy, completeness, or professional suitability of any AI-generated output. You are solely responsible for verifying all information, editing all content, and for the final integrity, accuracy, and outcomes of all materials, correspondence, or activities for employment, career related, or other purposes.

1. Why Use AI in Your Career Journey?

- Enhance your preparation: AI can help you practice, get feedback, and sharpen your career journey.
- Time saving: efficiency and scalability
- Tapping into the vast data that AI is ready to synthesize: For example, job market and industry research, idea generation, etc.
- Simulation of different audiences: recruiters, hiring managers, Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS), etc.
- Skill gap identification and personalized recommendations
- Language and writing support. AI can help you edit and polish your application materials, such as your resume and cover letter, and offer feedback on tone, clarity, and structure.

2. How can AI help me in my job search?

- Resume and cover letter editing and tailoring
- Assistance with other job search correspondence, such as thank-you notes and networking communications.
- Interview preparation, mock interview Q&As

- Career exploration and industry/job market research

3. Limitations, Ethics, and Things to Consider

- AI has biases and makes mistakes
- Privacy and data security
- Over-reliance or loss of authenticity
- Academic integrity and professional ethics
- Critical thinking is still essential – AI should complement, not replace, your judgment, creativity, and own voice
- Organization policies about applicants using AI

4. General Tips

- **Be specific in your prompts:**

AI tools are trained on massive datasets and can provide highly tailored insights—but only if you're clear and detailed in your request. Include your goals, audience, tone, and relevant background.

- **Use your own voice:**

AI can assist with structure, grammar, and clarity, but your writing should still reflect your authentic tone, values, and personality—especially in cover letters, resumes, correspondence, or interview prep.

- **Iterative Prompting:**

You don't have to get everything right in one try. Ask follow-up questions like: "Can you make this more concise?" or "Refine this in a more conversational tone."

- **Always carefully review and edit AI responses:**

AI tools are language models that can sometimes make factual errors ("hallucinations") and false information, insert clichés, or overlook nuances. Always double-check outputs for accuracy.

- **Protect your privacy:**

Don't share your full name, phone number, or any other personally identifying information in open or public versions of AI tools.

- **Research organization policies:**

When applying to internships, jobs, or other career opportunities be sure to research whether the organization has any policies in regards to applicants utilizing AI.

- **Seek human opinion:**

AI is a powerful tool for editing and brainstorming, but it does not fully replace the sentiment and perception of a human reader. After using AI, consider bringing your draft to a career counselor, faculty mentor, or writing tutor for feedback.

- **Do the work:**

AI can help you proactively enhance your career development, however it is not meant to replace you investing the time and effort to do your own work. Leverage AI as an optimization tool rather than replacing your efforts and voice. You are responsible for any application materials you submit or correspondence you send.

5. Which AI Tools to Use

- There are a number of AI tools available to utilize. Google's AI products are USD's preferred set of AI tools. Google's AI products are now included in USD's Google license agreement and, when using your USD credentials, they are provided to you free of charge.
- Google's Gemini is now available at no cost to all USD students, faculty and staff. Gemini is similar to the paid version of ChatGPT but is more secure and protected because it: (a) does not use any USD data to train its underlying model; and (b) adheres to USD's privacy and data security standards. Gemini can assist with brainstorming, guided learning, content refinement, deep research, generating images/videos, coding software and more. You can even chat with it and ask questions about your own USD email, calendar and documents in Google Drive. Access Gemini through a web browser or via its mobile app (iOS and Android).
- Gemini has a built-in Gem called "Career Guide". It can be found by clicking *Explore Gems*.
- Using non-Google AI products - The use of Google's AI products does not mean that you cannot use other tools such as ChatGPT, Claude and Perplexity. The main point to remember is that these other tools are not secure or protected - that means that you should never share sensitive, private, confidential or institutional USD data/information with those

products. The only AI tools you may share sensitive, private, confidential, or institutional USD data/information are Google AI tools.

- To learn more about AI at USD visit the [AI@USD webpage](#)

6. Sample Prompts and Use Scenarios

- Resume and cover letter editing prompt samples
 - [Resume prompt sample 1](#)
 - [Resume prompt sample 2](#)
 - [Resume prompt sample 3](#)
 - [Cover letter prompt sample](#)
- [Interview preparation prompt sample](#)
- [Career exploration and industry research prompt sample 1](#)
- [Career exploration and industry research prompt sample 2](#)

7. Further Reading and Additional Resources

- [Navigating the job market with AI: A 2025 guide for job seekers](#)
- [Want to use AI as a career coach? Use these prompts](#)
- [How Students Should Not Use Generative AI in the Job Search](#)

Sample Prompt 1: Resume editing request

Tips: This is an example of a quick, one-off resume editing prompt. Even in short prompts, be sure to include three key elements:

1. *A brief summary of your background*
2. *The intended audience or employer/industry*
3. *The purpose of the resume (e.g., internship, full-time role, job fair, networking)*

While AI tools draw from massive datasets and can offer helpful guidance, the more specific your prompt is, the more accurate and relevant the response will be.

Example:

I am a third year Accounting major applying for summer internships with the Big4 accounting firms. This is a resume for the accounting recruitment fair, and I would like you to advise me from the perspective of a college recruiter from a big accounting firm.

Sample Prompt 2: Resume editing request – use delimiters to create a reusable template

Tips: ####s (delimiters) help structure your prompt by clearly labeling different sections, such as ####My Background or ####Target Audience. While optional, these markers make your prompt easier for AI to interpret and respond to accurately. They also allow you to build reusable templates for common tasks, such as resume reviews or cover letter drafts. Using clear delimiters improves clarity, especially when your prompt includes multiple parts or detailed instructions.

Example:

####Who Am I: I am a sophomore Electrical Engineering major

####What Am I Doing: Applying for an Electrical Engineering internship position at ABCcom

####My Audience: ABCcom college recruiter and likely Applicant Tracking System (ATS) screening

####AI Perspective: Assume the perspective of an experienced college recruiter from a large tech company such as ABCcom

####Specific Goals: Besides matching keywords and key skills, highlight my transferable experience since I haven't had internships before

####Job Description: [copy/paste job description, especially the responsibilities and requirements/qualifications]

####My Resume: [copy/paste the content of your resume. Omit your name, contact information and other personal information]

Sample Prompt 3: Resume Summary/Profile creation

Tips: If you have extensive work experience, adding a “Summary” section at the top of your resume can help highlight your most relevant skills and qualifications—especially those aligned with the job you’re targeting.

When asking AI to help you write this summary, be sure to provide:

- *The format you want (e.g., brief paragraph, bullet points, or a combination)*
- *The desired length or word count*

- *The job description and key qualifications for the role you're applying to*
The more context you give, the more tailored and effective the summary will be.

Delimiters: ####s (delimiters) help structure your prompt by clearly labeling different sections, such as ####My Background or ####Target Audience. While optional, these markers make your prompt easier for AI to interpret and respond to accurately. They also allow you to build reusable templates for common tasks, such as resume reviews or cover letter drafts. Using clear delimiters improves clarity, especially when your prompt includes multiple parts or detailed instructions.

Example:

####Intention: Create a brief, 80-word “Summary” section of my resume, highlighting most relevant skills that match the specific job that I am applying for.

####Background: I have 10 years of experience in software development and now I am completing a master’s degree in Applied Artificial Intelligence. I want to highlight my [areas of relevant expertise, coursework, etc.].

####Job Description: [copy/paste job description, especially the responsibilities and requirements/qualifications]

####My Resume: [copy/paste the content of your resume. Omit your name, contact information and other personal information]

Prompt Sample 4: Cover Letter Optimization

*Tips: Similar to resume optimization, the AI can most effectively optimize your cover letter if you provide specific background information such as who you are, the purpose and the audience of the letter, and the specific company and position that you are applying to. To maintain your own voice and writing style, it is best to provide your rough draft in the prompt instead of asking AI to write the letter from scratch. **Use AI as a writing assistant, not the writer.***

Delimiters: ####s (delimiters) help structure your prompt by clearly labeling different sections, such as ####My Background or ####Target Audience. While optional, these markers make your prompt easier for AI to interpret and respond to accurately. They also allow you to build reusable templates for common tasks, such as resume reviews or cover letter drafts. Using clear delimiters improves clarity, especially when your prompt includes multiple parts or detailed instructions.

Example:

###Purpose: Optimizing my cover letter for my summer research application

###Background: I am a third year Biology major with prior experience conducting research on campus. This is the first time I am applying for a research position with a biotech company

###Perspective: Advise me as if you are a recruiter from a major biotech company, especially with experience recruiting interns or entry level research positions.

###Tone and style: I want to sound personable and authentic, but still professionally appropriate for the biotech industry. Please try to keep my original voice while providing editing suggestions.

###Job Description: [copy/paste job description, especially the responsibilities and requirements/qualifications]

###My Cover Letter: [copy/paste the draft of your cover letter. Omit name and personal information]

Prompt Sample 5: Interview Preparation

Tips: When using AI to help you prepare for an interview, be sure to include:

- *Basic information about yourself, the employer, and the position*
- *The **interview format** (e.g., phone screen, panel, behavioral, technical)*
- *The type of questions or topics you want to practice*

You can also tell the AI how you'd like to practice—for example:

- *General interview tips*
- *Mock Q&A, one question at a time*
- *Feedback on your sample answers*

The more specific you are, the more effective and tailored your practice session will be.

Delimiters: ####s (delimiters) help structure your prompt by clearly labeling different sections, such as ####My Background or ####Target Audience. While optional, these markers make your prompt easier for AI to interpret and respond to accurately. They also allow you to build reusable templates for common tasks, such as resume reviews or cover letter drafts. Using clear delimiters improves clarity, especially when your prompt includes multiple parts or detailed instructions.

Example:

###About me: graduating senior, Architecture major, [summarize relevant skills], had one internship with a construction company prior.

###About the Organization: XYZ company, a construction and renovation contractor specializing in hospitals and office buildings.

###The position: Project Coordinator position in the Renovation department.

###Format: This is a second round, in-person interview with a panel of 4 interviewers.

###Audience: The panel includes the hiring manager (Project Manager), a team member from the same department (Project Coordinator), the department head (VP of Project Operations), and an HR specialist.

###Perspective: When coaching and advising me, please prioritize the perspective of the hiring manager.

###Practice: I would like to practice behavioral interview questions and STAR storytelling. Please read the following job descriptions and come up with 3 likely behavioral questions. Let's practice one question at a time – you ask, I answer, you critique, and repeat.

###Job Description: [copy/paste job description, especially the responsibilities and requirements/qualifications]

###My Resume: [copy/paste the content of your resume. Omit your name, contact information and other personal information]

Prompt Sample 6: Career exploration and industry research

Tips: Career exploration can feel open-ended, and you may not always have a specific job title or description in mind. To make your conversation with AI more focused and useful, start by sharing some key information about yourself, such as:

- *Background (e.g., major, experience)*
- *Your interests, skills, values, and needs*
- *Any specific preferences (e.g., location, work-life balance, further education, immediate transition or long-term planning)*

Then, clarify what you want AI to help with. For example:

- *Identifying job roles that match your current skills*
- *Exploring industries aligned with your interests and values*
- *Understanding skill gaps for a role or industry you're curious about*

The more direction you give, the more tailored and insightful the conversation will be.

Delimiters: ####s (delimiters) help structure your prompt by clearly labeling different sections, such as ####My Background or ####Target Audience. While optional, these markers make your prompt easier for AI to interpret and respond to accurately. They also allow you to build reusable templates for common tasks, such as resume reviews or cover letter drafts. Using clear delimiters improves clarity, especially when your prompt includes multiple parts or detailed instructions.

Example:

####About me: A marketing major, senior, with some experience in social media marketing through internships and student organization work. Now I am interested in exploring careers in branding and product marketing, and how my previous experience and marketing coursework can help me connect to my future career.

####Interest: I like working with people and I like teaching people new concepts. I would like to explore where and how my skills may be valuable in marketing settings.

####Skills: I have done social media internships and know how to create content, run campaigns, and look at analytics. I'm good at identifying trends and explaining ideas clearly to different audiences.

####Values for an ideal job: I want a job where I can help build brands that actually connect with people. Working with a team is really important to me, and I like places that let you be creative and try new things. I also care about working somewhere that's honest, ethical, and values its people.

####Needs for an ideal job: Prefer West coast, [ideal salary range] to start, hybrid or flexible work schedule, and opportunities for career growth. I am open to entry level marketing jobs that help me build the right skills.

####Hope to learn: I am just starting to figure out what's out there beyond social media management. I want to explore different entry level roles in branding, product marketing, or marketing strategy. Later, I can narrow it down to specific industries, companies, and job titles.

###Perspective: Please converse with me as if you are an experienced career coach who has lots of experience in the marketing field. Also please add perspective as a corporate recruiter who recruits for related roles for new college grads.

Prompt Sample 7: Career exploration and industry research (early college)

***Tips:** Career exploration can feel open-ended, especially early in college, and you might not have a clear idea of a specific job or career path yet. To make your conversation with AI more useful, you can start by sharing a few things about yourself, such as:*

- *Background: your major, any classes you enjoy, and any experiences so far (part-time jobs, clubs, volunteer work, hobbies).*
- *Interests, skills, values, and needs: even if you're not totally sure, mention what excites you, what you enjoy doing, or what kind of environment you like.*
- *Preferences: things like location, work-life balance, the possibility of grad school, or whether you want to focus on immediate opportunities versus long-term planning.*

Then, let AI know how you want it to help. For example, you could ask it to:

- *Explore industries you might enjoy based on your values or hobbies.*
- *Identify skills you might want to develop if you're curious about a field, without needing to commit to a specific role yet.*
- *Or just have an open-ended conversation about how your skills and interests may connect to different paths in the career world.*

The more direction you give, the more tailored and insightful the conversation will be.

Delimiters: ####s (delimiters) help structure your prompt by clearly labeling different sections, such as ####My Background or ####Target Audience. While optional, these markers make your prompt easier for AI to interpret and respond to accurately. They also allow you to build reusable templates for common tasks, such as resume reviews or cover letter drafts. Using clear delimiters improves clarity, especially when your prompt includes multiple parts or detailed instructions.

Example:

###About me: I thought I would be pre-med for years, but the more I think about med school and being a doctor, the more doubt I have. I am doing ok in my bio/biochem classes but I just don't enjoy them and I am not sure if I want to continue this path.

###Interest: I like helping people and solving problems. I have been playing sports since I was young, and health and fitness are topics that I am interested in.

###Skills: I haven't done much work except hospital volunteering. I think I am good at working with people and I am ok in science and labs too.

###Values for an ideal job: Helping people is essential. I would like to work in an environment where I can do the right things and make an impact.

###Needs for an ideal job: Good pay and job security. I don't mind extra schooling to get there. I like working hard and like to keep myself busy as long as my job keeps me motivated.

###Hope to learn: I just started to consider anything outside pre-med recently. I would like to chat about whether med-school/medicine is right for me, and what other careers may be potential good matches to consider.

###Perspective: I would like to have a more conversational and interactive discussion about careers. I would like to learn the perspectives from people who practice medicine and other career fields that we are exploring.